



Jobs over DEGREES

The right mix of resources, support and training will transform the youth of India and create livelihood across the spectrum

— By **G.V. PRASAD**

Even after years of Independence, we have lived with this myth that a higher educational qualification ensures employability. Today, the country is cluttered with all kinds of colleges and institutions, many with questionable credentials. Our education system churns out lakhs of graduates, post-graduates and even PhDs. Regretfully, not many have had meaningful employment, if employed at all. The curriculum is often obsolete, the quality of faculty is under-par and the overall employment-readiness low. Even worse is the alarming amount of school dropouts, most forced by economic constraints. The government-sponsored schemes,

though well intentioned, have had immense implementation gaps. With a burgeoning young population, we need to think differently; quickly and very substantially. If not addressed on a priority basis, it could have extreme implications.

We must acknowledge that employment and livelihood must get de-coupled from formal higher education. The reality is that most possible employment opportunities neither exist in the organised sector nor need graduates in such large numbers. We must look at greater vocational training and skills building that will create livelihood across the spectrum. An elaborate National Sample Survey (NSS) conducted in 1999-2000 estimated India's labour force at 406 million people with almost 93 per cent in the informal or unorganised sector. Today, even after

a decade, the situation would be no different. The country needs to dramatically augment its education system with more skill and vocation-based training. Even as we see unprecedented economic activity and infrastructure development, we lack basic skills to sustain the progress. It is obvious that there is a significant lack of the necessary skills sets, most of them not needing higher education of the classical kind. And yet we have so many unemployed youth, armed with the misleading 'higher education' qualifications, waiting for jobs commensurate to their degrees.

The paradox is thus of our own making. The result is perpetuation of poverty, right in the midst of substantial opportunity. The huge pool of school dropouts, made worse each year, is often condemned to remain economically disadvan-

 Each year, about 400 people do their masters in public health in India. But if India is to put even a single public health worker in each village, we will need five lakh trained people just to deliver public health programmes and messages.